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Job Search With a Record

Finding work, handling the background-check question, and telling your story.

A record makes the job search harder, not impossible. Employers hire people with records every day, and there are real strategies for finding those employers and handling the moment your history comes up. This guide is practical: where to look, what your rights are, and how to talk about your past without letting it define the conversation.

Employment laws vary by state and city. This is general guidance, not legal advice. If you believe you faced illegal discrimination, a local legal-aid office can advise you.

Know your rights before you apply

- Many states and cities have ban-the-box laws that delay when an employer can ask about convictions, often until later in hiring. Learn your state's rule.
- Under federal fair-hiring guidance, employers generally should weigh the nature of the offense, the time passed, and its relevance to the job, rather than a blanket no.
- If a background check is used to deny you, you often have a right to see it and respond. Ask.

Where the openings actually are

- ☐ Employers with fair-chance hiring policies (many large companies now have them).
- ☐ Industries with steady demand and fewer barriers: trades, warehousing, logistics, food service, manufacturing, some transportation.
- ☐ Staffing agencies that specifically place people with records.
- ☐ Reentry and workforce programs, which often have direct employer relationships.
- ☐ Federal bonding programs and tax credits that make hiring you easier for an employer.

The background-check moment

At some point your record will come up. Prepare for it so it is a calm, brief part of the conversation, not an ambush.

- Be honest. Do not lie on an application; a lie found later is worse than the record.
- Be brief. You do not owe the whole story. A sentence or two is usually enough.
- Take responsibility, then pivot forward: what you learned, what you have done since, why you are reliable now.
- Practice it out loud until it is steady and short. The calm matters as much as the words.

A short script you can adapt

“Yes, I have a record from [time frame]. I take responsibility for it. Since then I have [work, training, stability]. I am focused on doing good work here, and I am happy to answer any questions.”

Build the case for you

My strengths and what I have done since:

Three employers or programs to contact this week:

This workbook is educational and reflects lived and professional experience. It is not legal advice and does not create an attorney-client relationship. Laws and procedures vary by jurisdiction and change over time. For advice about your situation, consult a licensed attorney in your state.

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